

International AS and A-level **English Literature**

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Place in literary texts:
Combined poetry selections

Robert Frost, Thomas Hardy, Seamus Heaney
and William Wordsworth



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the United Kingdom



OxfordAQA International AS and A-level English Literature

Place in literary texts: poetry anthology

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1 Robert Frost selection

Mending Wall

- 1 Something there is that doesn't love a wall,
 That sends the frozen-ground-swell under it
 And spills the upper boulders in the sun,
 And makes gaps even two can pass abreast.
- 5 The work of hunters is another thing:
 I have come after them and made repair
 Where they have left not one stone on a stone,
 But they would have the rabbit out of hiding,
 To please the yelping dogs. The gaps I mean,
- 10 No one has seen them made or heard them made,
 But at spring mending-time we find them there.
 I let my neighbor know beyond the hill;
 And on a day we meet to walk the line
 And set the wall between us once again.
- 15 We keep the wall between us as we go.
 To each the boulders that have fallen to each.
 And some are loaves and some so nearly balls
 We have to use a spell to make them balance:
 "Stay where you are until our backs are turned!"
- 20 We wear our fingers rough with handling them.
 Oh, just another kind of outdoor game,
 One on a side. It comes to little more:
 There where it is we do not need the wall:
 He is all pine and I am apple orchard.
- 25 My apple trees will never get across
 And eat the cones under his pines, I tell him.
 He only says, "Good fences make good neighbors."
 Spring is the mischief in me, and I wonder

If I could put a notion in his head:

- 30 “*Why* do they make good neighbors? Isn’t it
Where there are cows? But here there are no cows.
Before I built a wall I’d ask to know
What I was walling in or walling out,
And to whom I was like to give offense.
- 35 Something there is that doesn’t love a wall,
That wants it down.” I could say “Elves” to him,
But it’s not elves exactly, and I’d rather
He said it for himself. I see him there,
Bringing a stone grasped firmly by the top
- 40 In each hand, like an old-stone savage armed.
He moves in darkness as it seems to me,
Not of woods only and the shade of trees.
He will not go behind his father’s saying,
And he likes having thought of it so well
- 45 He says again, “Good fences make good neighbors.”

The Black Cottage

- 1 We chanced in passing by that afternoon
To catch it in a sort of special picture
Among tar-banded ancient cherry trees,
Set well back from the road in rank lodged grass,
- 5 The little cottage we were speaking of,
A front with just a door between two windows,
Fresh painted by the shower a velvet black.
We paused, the minister and I, to look.
He made as if to hold it at arm's length
- 10 Or put the leaves aside that framed it in.
"Pretty," he said. "Come in. No one will care."
The path was a vague parting in the grass
That led us to a weathered windowsill.
We pressed our faces to the pane. "You see," he said,
- 15 "Everything's as she left it when she died.
Her sons won't sell the house or the things in it.
They say they mean to come and summer here
Where they were boys. They haven't come this year.
They live so far away—one is out West—
- 20 It will be hard for them to keep their word.
Anyway they won't have the place disturbed."
A buttoned haircloth lounge spread scrolling arms
Under a crayon portrait on the wall,
Done sadly from an old daguerreotype.
- 25 "That was the father as he went to war.
She always, when she talked about the war,
Sooner or later came and leaned, half knelt,
Against the lounge beside it, though I doubt
If such unlikeliest lines kept power to stir
- 30 Anything in her after all the years.
He fell at Gettysburg or Fredericksburg,

I ought to know—it makes a difference which:
Fredericksburg wasn't Gettysburg, of course.
But what I'm getting to is how forsaken
35 A little cottage this has always seemed;
Since she went, more than ever, but before—
I don't mean altogether by the lives
That had gone out of it, the father first,
Then the two sons, till she was left alone.
40 (Nothing could draw her after those two sons.
She valued the considerate neglect
She had at some cost taught them after years.)
I mean by the world's having passed it by—
As we almost got by this afternoon.
45 It always seems to me a sort of mark
To measure how far fifty years have brought us.
Why not sit down if you are in no haste?
These doorsteps seldom have a visitor.
The warping boards pull out their own old nails
50 With none to tread and put them in their place.
She had her own idea of things, the old lady.
And she liked talk. She had seen Garrison
And Whittier, and had her story of them.
One wasn't long in learning that she thought,
55 Whatever else the Civil War was for,
It wasn't just to keep the States together,
Nor just to free the slaves, though it did both.
She wouldn't have believed those ends enough
To have given outright for them all she gave.
60 Her giving somehow touched the principle
That all men are created free and equal.
And to hear her quaint phrases—so removed
From the world's view today of all those things.
That's a hard mystery of Jefferson's.

- 65 What did he mean? Of course the easy way
 Is to decide it simply isn't true.
 It may not be. I heard a fellow say so.
 But never mind, the Welshman got it planted
 Where it will trouble us a thousand years.
- 70 Each age will have to reconsider it.
 You couldn't tell her what the West was saying,
 And what the South, to her serene belief.
 She had some art of hearing and yet not
 Hearing the latter wisdom of the world.
- 75 White was the only race she ever knew.
 Black she had scarcely seen, and yellow never.
 But how could they be made so very unlike
 By the same hand working in the same stuff?
 She had supposed the war decided that.
- 80 What are you going to do with such a person?
 Strange how such innocence gets its own way.
 I shouldn't be surprised if in this world
 It were the force that would at last prevail.
 Do you know but for her there was a time
- 85 When, to please younger members of the church,
 Or rather say non-members in the church,
 Whom we all have to think of nowadays,
 I would have changed the Creed a very little?
 Not that she ever had to ask me not to;
- 90 It never got so far as that; but the bare thought
 Of her old tremulous bonnet in the pew,
 And of her half asleep, was too much for me.
 Why, I might wake her up and startle her.
 It was the words 'descended into Hades'
- 95 That seemed too pagan to our liberal youth.
 You know they suffered from a general onslaught.
 And well, if they weren't true why keep right on

- Saying them like the heathen? We could drop them.
Only—there was the bonnet in the pew.
- 100 Such a phrase couldn't have meant much to her.
But suppose she had missed it from the Creed,
As a child misses the unsaid Good-night
And falls asleep with heartache—how should I feel?
I'm just as glad she made me keep hands off,
- 105 For, dear me, why abandon a belief
Merely because it ceases to be true.
Cling to it long enough, and not a doubt
It will turn true again, for so it goes.
Most of the change we think we see in life
- 110 Is due to truths being in and out of favor.
As I sit here, and oftentimes, I wish
I could be monarch of a desert land
I could devote and dedicate forever
To the truths we keep coming back and back to.
- 115 So desert it would have to be, so walled
By mountain ranges half in summer snow,
No one would covet it or think it worth
The pains of conquering to force change on.
Scattered oases where men dwelt, but mostly
- 120 Sand dunes held loosely in tamarisk
Blown over and over themselves in idleness.
Sand grains should sugar in the natal dew
The babe born to the desert, the sandstorm
Retard mid-waste my cowering caravans—
- 125 "There are bees in this wall." He struck the clapboards,
Fierce heads looked out; small bodies pivoted.
We rose to go. Sunset blazed on the windows.

After Apple-Picking

- 1 My long two-pointed ladder's sticking through a tree
 Toward heaven still,
 And there's a barrel that I didn't fill
 Beside it, and there may be two or three
- 5 Apples I didn't pick upon some bough.
 But I am done with apple-picking now.
 Essence of winter sleep is on the night,
 The scent of apples: I am drowsing off.
 I cannot rub the strangeness from my sight
- 10 I got from looking through a pane of glass
 I skimmed this morning from the drinking trough
 And held against the world of hoary grass.
 It melted, and I let it fall and break.
 But I was well
- 15 Upon my way to sleep before it fell,
 And I could tell
 What form my dreaming was about to take.
 Magnified apples appear and disappear,
 Stem end and blossom end,
- 20 And every fleck of russet showing clear.
 My instep arch not only keeps the ache,
 It keeps the pressure of a ladder-round.
 I feel the ladder sway as the boughs bend.
 And I keep hearing from the cellar bin
- 25 The rumbling sound
 Of load on load of apples coming in.
 For I have had too much
 Of apple-picking: I am overtired
 Of the great harvest I myself desired.
- 30 There were ten thousand thousand fruit to touch,

Cherish in hand, lift down, and not let fall.

For all

That struck the earth,

No matter if not bruised or spiked with stubble,

35 Went surely to the cider-apple heap

As of no worth.

One can see what will trouble

This sleep of mine, whatever sleep it is.

Were he not gone,

40 The woodchuck could say whether it's like his

Long sleep, as I describe its coming on,

Or just some human sleep.

The Wood-Pile

- 1 Out walking in the frozen swamp one gray day,
I paused and said, "I will turn back from here.
No, I will go on farther—and we shall see."
The hard snow held me, save where now and then
- 5 One foot went through. The view was all in lines
Straight up and down of tall slim trees
Too much alike to mark or name a place by
So as to say for certain I was here
Or somewhere else: I was just far from home.
- 10 A small bird flew before me. He was careful
To put a tree between us when he lighted,
And say no word to tell me who he was
Who was so foolish as to think what *he* thought.
He thought that I was after him for a feather—
- 15 The white one in his tail; like one who takes
Everything said as personal to himself.
One flight out sideways would have undeceived him.
And then there was a pile of wood for which
I forgot him and let his little fear
- 20 Carry him off the way I might have gone,
Without so much as wishing him good-night.
He went behind it to make his last stand.
It was a cord of maple, cut and split
And piled—and measured, four by four by eight.
- 25 And not another like it could I see.
No runner tracks in this year's snow looped near it.
And it was older sure than this year's cutting,
Or even last year's or the year's before.
The wood was gray and the bark warping off it
- 30 And the pile somewhat sunken. Clematis

Had wound strings round and round it like a bundle.
What held it, though, on one side was a tree
Still growing, and on one a stake and prop,
These latter about to fall. I thought that only
35 Someone who lived in turning to fresh tasks
Could so forget his handiwork on which
He spent himself, the labor of his ax,
And leave it there far from a useful fireplace
To warm the frozen swamp as best it could
40 With the slow smokeless burning of decay.

The Road Not Taken

- 1 Two roads diverged in a yellow wood,
And sorry I could not travel both
And be one traveler, long I stood
And looked down one as far as I could
5 To where it bent in the undergrowth;
- Then took the other, as just as fair,
And having perhaps the better claim,
Because it was grassy and wanted wear;
Though as for that, the passing there
10 Had worn them really about the same,
- And both that morning equally lay
In leaves no step had trodden black.
Oh, I kept the first for another day!
Yet knowing how way leads on to way,
15 I doubted if I should ever come back.
- I shall be telling this with a sigh
Somewhere ages and ages hence:
Two roads diverged in a wood, and I –
I took the one less traveled by,
20 And that has made all the difference.

Birches

- 1 When I see birches bend to left and right
 Across the lines of straighter darker trees,
 I like to think some boy's been swinging them.
 But swinging doesn't bend them down to stay
- 5 As ice storms do. Often you must have seen them
 Loaded with ice a sunny winter morning
 After a rain. They click upon themselves
 As the breeze rises, and turn many-colored
 As the stir cracks and crazes their enamel.
- 10 Soon the sun's warmth makes them shed crystal shells
 Shattering and avalanching on the snow crust –
 Such heaps of broken glass to sweep away
 You'd think the inner dome of heaven had fallen.
 They are dragged to the withered bracken by the load,
- 15 And they seem not to break; though once they are bowed
 So low for long, they never right themselves:
 You may see their trunks arching in the woods
 Years afterwards, trailing their leaves on the ground
 Like girls on hands and knees that throw their hair
- 20 Before them over their heads to dry in the sun.
 But I was going to say when Truth broke in
 With all her matter of fact about the ice storm,
 I should prefer to have some boy bend them
 As he went out and in to fetch the cows –
- 25 Some boy too far from town to learn baseball,
 Whose only play was what he found himself,
 Summer or winter, and could play alone.
 One by one he subdued his father's trees
 By riding them down over and over again
- 30 Until he took the stiffness out of them,

And not one but hung limp, not one was left
For him to conquer. He learned all there was
To learn about not launching out too soon
And so not carrying the tree away
35 Clear to the ground. He always kept his poise
To the top branches, climbing carefully
With the same pains you use to fill a cup
Up to the brim, and even above the brim.
Then he flung outward, feet first, with a swish,
40 Kicking his way down through the air to the ground.
So was I once myself a swinger of birches.
And so I dream of going back to be.
It's when I'm weary of considerations,
And life is too much like a pathless wood
45 Where your face bums and tickles with the cobwebs
Broken across it, and one eye is weeping
From a twig's having lashed across it open.
I'd like to get away from earth awhile
And then come back to it and begin over.
50 May no fate willfully misunderstand me
And half grant what I wish and snatch me away
Not to return. Earth's the right place for love:
I don't know where it's likely to go better.
I'd like to go by climbing a birch tree,
55 And climb black branches up a snow-white trunk
Toward heaven, till the tree could bear no more,
But dipped its top and set me down again.
That would be good both going and coming back.
One could do worse than be a swinger of birches.

“Out, Out –”

- 1 The buzz saw snarled and rattled in the yard
And made dust and dropped stove-length sticks of wood,
Sweet-scented stuff when the breeze drew across it.
And from there those that lifted eyes could count
- 5 Five mountain ranges one behind the other
Under the sunset far into Vermont.
And the saw snarled and rattled, snarled and rattled,
As it ran light, or had to bear a load.
And nothing happened: day was all but done.
- 10 Call it a day, I wish they might have said
To please the boy by giving him the half hour
That a boy counts so much when saved from work.
His sister stood beside them in her apron
To tell them “Supper.” At the word, the saw,
- 15 As if to prove saws knew what supper meant,
Leaped out at the boy’s hand, or seemed to leap—
He must have given the hand. However it was,
Neither refused the meeting. But the hand!
The boy’s first outcry was a rueful laugh,
- 20 As he swung toward them holding up the hand,
Half in appeal, but half as if to keep
The life from spilling. Then the boy saw all—
Since he was old enough to know, big boy
Doing a man’s work, though a child at heart—
- 25 He saw all spoiled. “Don’t let him cut my hand off—
The doctor, when he comes. Don’t let him, sister!”
So. But the hand was gone already.
The doctor put him in the dark of ether.
He lay and puffed his lips out with his breath.
- 30 And then – the watcher at his pulse took fright.

No one believed. They listened at his heart.

Little—less—nothing!—and that ended it.

No more to build on there. And they, since they

Were not the one dead, turned to their affairs.

Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening

1 Whose woods these are I think I know.
 His house is in the village, though;
 He will not see me stopping here
 To watch his woods fill up with snow.

5 My little horse must think it queer
 To stop without a farmhouse near
 Between the woods and frozen lake
 The darkest evening of the year.

 He gives his harness bells a shake
10 To ask if there is some mistake.
 The only other sound's the sweep
 Of easy wind and downy flake.

 The woods are lovely, dark, and deep,
 But I have promises to keep,
15 And miles to go before I sleep,
 And miles to go before I sleep.

A Brook in the City

- 1 The farmhouse lingers, though averse to square
 With the new city street it has to wear
 A number in. But what about the brook
 That held the house as in an elbow-crook?
- 5 I ask as one who knew the brook, its strength
 And impulse, having dipped a finger length
 And made it leap my knuckle, having tossed
 A flower to try its currents where they crossed.
 The meadow grass could be cemented down
- 10 From growing under pavements of a town;
 The apple trees be sent to hearthstone flame.
 Is water wood to serve a brook the same?
 How else dispose of an immortal force
 No longer needed? Staunch it at its source
- 15 With cinder loads dumped down? The brook was thrown
 Deep in a sewer dungeon under stone
 In fetid darkness still to live and run—
 And all for nothing it had ever done,
 Except forget to go in fear perhaps.
- 20 No one would know except for ancient maps
 That such a brook ran water. But I wonder
 If from its being kept forever under,
 The thoughts may not have risen that so keep
 This new-built city from both work and sleep.

On Looking Up By Chance At The Constellations

- 1 You'll wait a long, long time for anything much
 To happen in heaven beyond the floats of cloud
 And the Northern Lights that run like tingling nerves.
 The sun and moon get crossed, but they never touch,
5 Nor strike out fire from each other, nor crash out loud.
 The planets seem to interfere in their curves,
 But nothing ever happens, no harm is done.
 We may as well go patiently on with our life,
 And look elsewhere than to stars and moon and sun
10 For the shocks and changes we need to keep us sane.
 It is true the longest drouth will end in rain,
 The longest peace in China will end in strife.
 Still it wouldn't reward the watcher to stay awake
 In hopes of seeing the calm of heaven break
15 On his particular time and personal sight.
 That calm seems certainly safe to last tonight.

Desert Places

1 Snow falling and night falling fast, oh, fast
 In a field I looked into going past,
 And the ground almost covered smooth in snow,
 But a few weeds and stubble showing last.

5 The woods around it have it—it is theirs.
 All animals are smothered in their lairs.
 I am too absent-spirited to count;
 The loneliness includes me unawares.

 And lonely as it is, that loneliness
10 Will be more lonely ere it will be less—
 A blanker whiteness of benighted snow
 With no expression, nothing to express.

 They cannot scare me with their empty spaces
 Between stars—on stars where no human race is.
15 I have it in me so much nearer home
 To scare myself with my own desert places.

An Unstamped Letter in our Rural Letter Box

- 1 Last night your watchdog barked all night,
 So once you rose and lit the light.
 It wasn't someone at your locks.
 No, in your rural letter box
- 5 I leave this note without a stamp
 To tell you it was just a tramp
 Who used your pasture for a camp.
 There, pointed like the pip of spades,
 The young spruce made a suite of glades
- 10 So regular that in the dark
 The place was like a city park.
 There I elected to demur
 Beneath a low-slung juniper
 That like a blanket to my chin
- 15 Kept some dew out and some heat in,
 Yet left me freely face to face
 All night with universal space.
 It may have been at two o'clock
 That under me a point of rock
- 20 Developed in the grass and fern,
 And as I woke afraid to turn
 Or so much as uncross my feet,
 Lest having wasted precious heat
 I never should again be warmed,
- 25 The largest firedrop ever formed
 From two stars' having coalesced
 Went streaking molten down the west.
 And then your tramp astrologer
 From seeing this undoubted stir

- 30 In Heaven's firm-set firmament,
Himself had the equivalent,
Only within. Inside the brain
Two memories that long had lain
Now quivered toward each other, lipped
- 35 Together, and together slipped;
And for a moment all was plain
That men have thought about in vain.
Please, my involuntary host,
Forgive me if I seem to boast.
- 40 'Tis possible you may have seen,
Albeit through a rusty screen,
The same sign Heaven showed your guest.
Each knows his own discernment best.
You have had your advantages.
- 45 Things must have happened to you, yes,
And have occurred to you no doubt,
If not indeed from sleeping out,
Then from the work you went about
In farming well—or pretty well.
- 50 And it is partly to compel
Myself, in *forma pauperis*,
To say as much I write you this.

2 Thomas Hardy selection

Neutral Tones

1 We stood by a pond that winter day,
And the sun was white, as though chidden of God,
And a few leaves lay on the starving sod;
– They had fallen from an ash, and were grey.

5 Your eyes on me were as eyes that rove
Over tedious riddles of years ago;
And some words played between us to and fro
On which lost the more by our love.

The smile on your mouth was the deadest thing
10 Alive enough to have strength to die;
And a grin of bitterness swept thereby
Like an ominous bird a-wing ...

Since then, keen lessons that love deceives,
And wrings with wrong, have shaped to me
15 Your face, and the God-curst sun, and a tree,
And a pond edged with greyish leaves.

At An Inn

1 When we as strangers sought
 Their catering care,
 Veiled smiles bespoke their thought
 Of what we were.

5 They warmed as they opined
 Us more than friends –
 That we had all resigned
 For love's dear ends.

 And that swift sympathy
10 With living love
 Which quicks the world – maybe
 The spheres above,
 Made them our ministers,
 Moved them to say,
15 'Ah, God, that bliss like theirs
 Would flush our day!'

 And we were left alone
 As Love's own pair;
 Yet never the love-light shone
20 Between us there!
 But that which chilled the breath
 Of afternoon,
 And palsied unto death
 The pane-fly's tune.

25 The kiss their zeal foretold,
 And now deemed come,
 Came not: within his hold

Love lingered numb.

Why cast he on our port

30 A bloom not ours?

Why shaped us for his sport

In after-hours?

As we seemed we were not

That day afar,

35 And now we seem not what

We aching are.

O severing sea and land,

O laws of men,

Ere death, once let us stand

40 As we stood then!

At a Lunar Eclipse

- 1 Thy shadow, Earth, from Pole to Central Sea,
 Now steals along upon the Moon's meek shine
 In even monochrome and curving line
 Of imperturbable serenity.
- 5 How shall I link such sun-cast symmetry
 With the torn troubled form I know as thine.
 That profile, placid as a brow divine,
 With continents of moil and misery?
- And can immense Mortality but throw
- 10 So small a shade, and Heaven's high human scheme
 Be hemmed within the coasts yon arc implies?
- Is such the stellar gauge of earthly show,
 Nation at war with nation, brains that teem,
 Heroes, and women fairer than the skies?

To an Unborn Pauper Child

1

- 1 Breathe not, hid Heart: cease silently,
And though thy birth-hour beckons thee,
Sleep the long sleep;
The Doomsters heap
- 5 Travails and teens around us here,
And Time-wraiths turn our songsingings to fear.

2

- Hark, how the peoples surge and sigh,
And laughters fail, and greetings die:
Hopes dwindle; yea,
- 10 Faiths waste away,
Affections and enthusiasms numb;
Thou canst not mend these things if thou dost come.

3

- Had I the ear of wombèd souls
Ere their terrestrial chart unrolls,
- 15 And thou wert free
To cease, or be,
Then would I tell thee all I know,
And put it to thee: Wilt thou take Life so?

4

- Vain vow! No hint of mine may hence
- 20 To theeward fly: to thy locked sense
Explain none can
Life's pending plan:
Thou wilt thy ignorant entry make

Though skies spout fire and blood and nations quake.

5

- 25 Fain would I, dear, find some shut plot
Of earth's wide wold for thee, where not
One tear, one qualm,
Should break the calm.
But I am weak as thou and bare;
30 No man can change the common lot to rare.

6

- Must come and bide. And such are we –
Unreasoning, sanguine, visionary –
That I can hope
Health, love, friends, scope
35 In full for thee; can dream thou'lt find
Joys seldom yet attained by humankind!

The Darkling Thrush

- 1 I leant upon a coppice gate
 When Frost was spectre-grey,
And Winter's dregs made desolate
 The weakening eye of day.
- 5 The tangled bine-stems scored the sky
 Like strings of broken lyres,
And all mankind that haunted nigh
 Had sought their household fires.
- The land's sharp features seemed to be
- 10 The Century's corpse outleant,
His crypt the cloudy canopy,
 The wind his death-lament.
The ancient pulse of germ and birth
 Was shrunken hard and dry,
- 15 And every spirit upon earth
 Seemed fervourless as I.
- At once a voice arose among
 The bleak twigs overhead
In a full-hearted evensong
 Of joy illimited;
- 20 An aged thrush, frail, gaunt, and small,
 In blast-beruffled plume,
Had chosen thus to fling his soul
 Upon the growing gloom.
- 25 So little cause for carolings
 Of such ecstatic sound
Was written on terrestrial things

Afar or nigh around,
That I could think there trembled through
30 His happy good-night air
Some blessed Hope, whereof he knew
And I was unaware.

The Self-Unseeing

1 Here is the ancient floor,
 Footworn and hollowed and thin,
 Here was the former door
 Where the dead feet walked in.

5 She sat here in her chair,
 Smiling into the fire;
 He who played stood there,
 Bowing it higher and higher.

 Childlike, I danced in a dream;
10 Blessings emblazoned that day;
 Everything glowed with a gleam;
 Yet we were looking away!

Channel Firing

- 1 That night your great guns, unawares,
 Shook all our coffins as we lay,
 And broke the chancel window-squares,
 We thought it was the Judgment-day
- 5 And sat upright. While drearisome
 Arose the howl of wakened hounds:
 The mouse let fall the altar-crumb,
 The worms drew back into the mounds,
- The glebe cow drooled. Till God called, 'No;
- 10 It's gunnery practice out at sea
 Just as before you went below;
 The world is as it used to be:
- 'All nations striving strong to make
 Red war yet redder. Mad as hatters
- 15 They do no more for Christ's sake
 Than you who are helpless in such matters.
- 'That this is not the judgment-hour
 For some of them's a blessed thing,
 For if it were they'd have to scour
- 20 Hell's floor for so much threatening . .
- 'Ha, ha. It will be warmer when
 I blow the trumpet (if indeed
 I ever do; for you are men,
 And rest eternal sorely need).'

25 So down we lay again. 'I wonder,
 Will the world ever saner be,'
 Said one, 'than when He sent us under
 In our indifferent century!'

 And many a skeleton shook his head.
30 'Instead of preaching forty year,'
 My neighbour Parson Thirdly said,
 'I wish I had stuck to pipes and beer.'

 Again the guns disturbed the hour,
 Roaring their readiness to avenge,
35 As far inland as Stourton Tower,
 And Camelot, and starlit Stonehenge.

The Convergence of the Twain

(Lines on the loss of the Titanic)

1

1 In a solitude of the sea
 Deep from human vanity,
And the Pride of life that planned her, stilly crouches she.

2

 Steel chambers, late the pyres
5 Of her salamandrine fires,
Cold currents thrid, and turn to rhythmic tidal lyres.

3

 Over the mirrors meant
 To glass the opulent
The sea-worm crawls – grotesque, slimed, dumb, indifferent.

4

10 Jewels in joy designed
 To ravish the sensuous mind
Lie lightless, all their sparkles bleared and black and blind.

5

 Dim moon-eyed fishes near
 Gaze at the gilded gear
15 And query: 'What does this vaingloriousness down here?'

6

 Well: while was fashioning
 This creature of cleaving wing,
The Immanent Will that stirs and urges everything

7

Prepared a sinister mate
20 For her – so gaily great –
A Shape of Ice, for the time far and dissociate.

8

And as the smart ship grew
In stature, grace, and hue,
In shadowy silent distance grew the Iceberg too.

9

25 Alien they seemed to be:
No mortal eye could see
The intimate welding of their later history,

10

Or sign that they were bent
By paths coincident
30 On being anon twin halves of one august event.

11

Till the Spinner of the Years
Said 'New!' And each one hears,
And consummation comes, and jars two hemispheres.

The Going

1 Why did you give no hint that night
 That quickly after the morrow's dawn,
 And calmly, as if indifferent quite,
 You would close your term here, up and be gone

5 Where I could not follow
 With wing of swallow
 To gain one glimpse of you ever anon!

 Never to bid goodbye,
 Or lip me the softest call,
10 Or utter a wish for a word, while I
 Saw morning harden upon the wall,
 Unmoved, unknowing
 That your great going
 Had place that moment, and altered all.

15 Why do you make me leave the house
 And think for a breath it is you I see
 At the end of the alley of bending boughs
 Where so often at dusk you used to be;

 Till in darkening dankness
20 The yawning blankness
 Of the perspective sickens me!

 You were she who abode
 By those red-veined rocks far West,
 You were the swan-necked one who rode
25 Along the beetling Beeny Crest,
 And, reining nigh me,
 Would muse and eye me,

While life unrolled us its very best.

Why, then, latterly did we not speak,

30 Did we not think of those days long dead,

And ere your vanishing strive to seek

That time's renewal? We might have said,

 'In this bright spring weather

 We'll visit together

35 Those places that once we visited.'

Well, well! All's past amend,

Unchangeable. It must go.

I seem but a dead man held on end

To sink down soon . . . O you could not know

40 That such swift fleeing

No soul foreseeing –

Not even I – would undo me so!

After a Journey

- 1 Hereto I come to view a voiceless ghost;
 Whither, O whither will its whim now draw me?
Up the cliff, down, till I'm lonely, lost,
 And the unseen waters' ejaculations awe me.
- 5 Where you will next be there's no knowing,
Facing round about me everywhere,
 With your nut-coloured hair,
And grey eyes, and rose-flush coming and going.
- Yes: I have re-entered your olden haunts at last;
- 10 Through the years, through the dead scenes I have tracked you;
What have you now found to say of our past -
 Scanned across the dark space wherein I have lacked you?
Summer gave us sweets, but autumn wrought division?
 Things were not lastly as firstly well
- 15 With us twain, you tell?
But all's closed now, despite Time's derision.
- I see what you are doing: you are leading me on
 To the spots we knew when we haunted here together,
The waterfall, above which the mist-bow shone
- 20 At the then fair hour in the then fair weather,
And the cave just under, with a voice still so hollow
That it seems to call out to me from forty years ago,
 When you were all aglow,
And not the thin ghost that I now frailly follow!
- 25 Ignorant of what there is flitting here to see,
 The waked birds preen and the seals flop lazily;
Soon you will have, Dear, to vanish from me,

For the stars close their shutters and the dawn whitens hazily.

Trust me, I mind not, though Life lours,

30 The bringing me here; nay, bring me here again!

I am just the same as when

Our days were a joy, and our paths through flowers.

Beeny Cliff

1

1 O the opal and the sapphire of that wandering western sea,
And the woman riding high above with bright hair flapping free -
The woman whom I loved so, and who loyally loved me.

2

The pale mews plained below us, and the waves seemed far away
5 In a nether sky, engrossed in saying their ceaseless babbling say,
As we laughed light-heartedly aloft on that clear-sunned March day.

3

A little cloud then cloaked us, and there flew an irised rain,
And the Atlantic dyed its levels with a dull misfeatured stain,
And then the sun burst out again, and purples prinked the main.

4

10 - Still in all its chasmal beauty bulks old Beeny to the sky,
And shall she and I not go there once again now March is nigh,
And the sweet things said in that March say anew there by and by?

5

What if still in chasmal beauty looms that wild weird western shore,
The woman now is - elsewhere - whom the ambling pony bore,
15 And nor knows nor cares for Beeny, and will laugh there never more.

At Castle Boterel

1 As I drive to the junction of lane and highway,
And the drizzle bedrenches the waggonette,
I look behind at the fading byway,
And see on its slope, now glistening wet,
5 Distinctly yet

Myself and a girlish form benighted
In dry March weather. We climb the road
Beside a chaise. We had just alighted
To ease the sturdy pony's load
10 When he sighed and slowed.

What we did as we climbed, and what we talked of
Matters not much, nor to what it led, -
Something that life will not be balked of
Without rude reason till hope is dead,
15 And feeling fled.

It filled but a minute. But was there ever
A time of such quality, since or before,
In that hill's story? To one mind never,
Though it has been climbed, foot-swift, foot-sore,
20 By thousands more.

Primaeval rocks form the road's steep border,
And much have they faced there, first and last.
Of the transitory in Earth's long order;
But what they record in colour and cast
25 Is - that we two passed.

And to me, though Time's unflinching rigour,
In mindless rote, has ruled from sight
The substance now, one phantom figure
Remains on the slope, as when that night

30 Saw us alight.

I look and see it there, shrinking, shrinking,
I look back at it amid the rain
For the very last time; for my sand is sinking,
And I shall traverse old love's domain

35 Never again.

Places

1 Nobody says: Ah, that is the place
Where chanced, in the hollow of years ago,
What none of the Three Towns cared to know –
The birth of a little girl of grace -

5 The sweetest the house saw, first or last;
Yet it was so
On that day long past.

Nobody thinks: There, there she lay
In a room by the Hoe, like the bud of a flower,
10 And listened, just after the bedtime hour,
To the stammering chimes that used to play
The quaint Old Hundred-and-Thirteenth tune
In Saint Andrew's tower
Night, morn, and noon.

15 Nobody calls to mind that here
Upon Boterel Hill, where the waggoners skid,
With cheeks whose airy flush outbid
Fresh fruit in bloom, and free of fear,
She cantered down, as if she must fall
20 (Though she never did),
To the charm of all.

Nay: one there is to whom these things,
That nobody else's mind calls back,
Have a savour that scenes in being lack,
25 And a presence more than the actual brings;
To whom today is beneaped and stale,
And its urgent clack
But a vapid tale.

The Oxen

- 1 Christmas Eve, and twelve of the clock.
 ‘Now they are all on their knees,’
An elder said as we sat in a flock
 By the embers in hearthside ease.
- 5 We pictured the meek mild creatures where
 They dwelt in their strawy pen,
Nor did it occur to one of us there
To doubt they were kneeling then.
- So fair a fancy few would weave
- 10 In these years! Yet, I feel,
If someone said on Christmas Eve,
 ‘Come; see the oxen kneel
- ‘In the lonely barton by yonder coomb
 Our childhood used to know,’
- 15 I should go with him in the gloom,
Hoping it might be so.

In Time of 'The Breaking of Nations'

1

- 1 Only a man harrowing clods
 In a slow silent walk
With an old horse that stumbles and nods
 Half asleep as they stalk.

2

- 5 Only thin smoke without flame
 From the heaps of couch-grass;
Yet this will go onward the same
 Though Dynasties pass.

3

- Yonder a maid and her wight
10 Come whispering by:
War's annals will cloud into night
 Ere their story die.

3 Seamus Heaney selection

Mid-Term Break

- 1 I sat all morning in the college sick bay
Counting bells knelling classes to a close.
At two o'clock our neighbours drove me home.
- In the porch I met my father crying -
- 5 He had always taken funerals in his stride -
And Big Jim Evans saying it was a hard blow.
- The baby cooed and laughed and rocked the pram
When I came in, and I was embarrassed
By old men standing up to shake my hand
- 10 And tell me they were 'sorry for my trouble'.
Whispers informed strangers I was the eldest,
Away at school, as my mother held my hand
- In hers and coughed out angry tearless sighs.
At ten o'clock the ambulance arrived
- 15 With the corpse, stanced and bandaged by the nurses.
- Next morning I went up into the room. Snowdrops
And candles soothed the bedside; I saw him
For the first time in six weeks. Paler now,
- Wearing a poppy bruise on his left temple,
- 20 He lay in the four foot box as in his cot.
No gaudy scars, the bumper knocked him clear.
- A four foot box, a foot for every year.

Personal Helicon

For Michael Langley

- 1 As a child, they could not keep me from wells
 And old pumps with buckets and windlasses.
 I loved the dark drop, the trapped sky, the smells
 Of waterweed, fungus and dank moss.
- 5 One, in a brickyard, with a rotted board top.
 I savoured the rich crash when a bucket
 Plummeted down at the end of a rope.
 So deep you saw no reflection in it.
- A shallow one under a dry stone ditch
- 10 Fructified like any aquarium.
 When you dragged out long roots from the soft mulch
 A white face hovered over the bottom.
- Others had echoes, gave back your own call
 With a clean new music in it. And one
- 15 Was scarcsome for there, out of ferns and tall
 Foxgloves, a rat slapped across my reflection.
- Now, to pry into roots, to finger slime,
 To stare, big-eyed Narcissus, into some spring
 Is beneath all adult dignity. I rhyme
- 20 To see myself, to set the darkness echoing.

The Peninsula

- 1 When you have nothing more to say, just drive
 For a day all round the peninsula.
 The sky is tall as over a runway,
 The land without marks so you will not arrive
- 5 But pass through, though always skirting landfall.
 At dusk, horizons drink down sea and hill,
 The ploughed field swallows the whitewashed gable
 And you're in the dark again. Now recall
- The glazed foreshore and silhouetted log,
10 That rock where breakers shredded into rags,
 The leggy birds stilted on their own legs,
 Islands riding themselves out into the fog
- And drive back home, still with nothing to say
 Except that now you will uncode all landscapes
- 15 By this: things founded clean on their own shapes,
 Water and ground in their extremity.

Requiem for the Croppies

- 1 The pockets of our greatcoats full of barley –
 No kitchens on the run, no striking camp –
 We moved quick and sudden in our own country.
 The priest lay behind ditches with the tramp.
- 5 A people, hardly marching - on the hike –
 We found new tactics happening each day:
 We'd cut through reins and rider with the pike
 And stampede cattle into infantry,
 Then retreat through hedges where cavalry must be
- 10 thrown.
 Until, on Vinegar Hill, the fatal conclave.
 Terraced thousands died, shaking scythes at cannon.
 The hillside blushed, soaked in our broken wave.
 They buried us without shroud or coffin
- 15 And in August the barley grew up out of the grave.

Bogland

- 1 We have no prairies
To slice a big sun at evening –
Everywhere the eye concedes to
Encroaching horizon,
- 5 Is wooed into the cyclops' eye
Of a tarn. Our unfenced country
Is bog that keeps crusting
Between the sights of the sun.
- They've taken the skeleton
- 10 Of the Great Irish Elk
Out of the peat, set it up
An astounding crate full of air.
- Butter sunk under
More than a hundred years
- 15 Was recovered salty and white.
The ground itself is kind, black butter
- Melting and opening underfoot,
Missing its last definition
By millions of years.
- 20 They'll never dig coal here,
- Only the waterlogged trunks
Of great firs, soft as pulp.
Our pioneers keep striking
Inwards and downwards,

- 25 Every layer they strip
 Seems camped on before.
 The bogholes might be Atlantic seepage.
 The wet centre is bottomless.

Anahorish

- 1 My 'place of clear water',
 the first hill in the world
 where springs washed into
 the shiny grass
- 5 and darkened cobbles
 in the bed of the lane.
 Anahorish, soft gradient
 of consonant, vowel-meadow,
- after-image of lamps
- 10 swung through the yards
 on winter evenings.
 With pails and barrows
- those mound-dwellers
 go waist-deep in mist
- 15 to break the light ice
 at wells and dunghills.

A New Song

1 I met a girl from Derrygarve
And the name, a lost potent musk,
Recalled the river's long swerve,
A kingfisher's blue bolt at dusk

5 And stepping stones like black molars
Sunk in the ford, the shifty glaze
Of the whirlpool, the Moyola
Pleasuring beneath alder trees.

And Derrygarve, I thought, was just:
10 Vanished music, twilit water –
A smooth libation of the past
Poured by this chance vestal daughter.

But now our river tongues must rise
From licking deep in native haunts
15 To flood, with vowelling embrace,
Demesnes staked out in consonants.

And Castledawson we'll enlist
And Upperlands, each planted bawn –
Like bleaching-greens resumed by grass –
20 A vocable, as rath and bullaun.

The Tollund Man

I

1 Some day I will go to Aarhus
 To see his peat-brown head,
 The mild pods of his eye-lids,
 His pointed skin cap.

5 In the flat country near by
 Where they dug him out,
 His last gruel of winter seeds
 Caked in his stomach,

 Naked except for
10 The cap, noose and girdle,
 I will stand a long time.
 Bridegroom to the goddess,

 She tightened her torc on him
 And opened her fen,
15 Those dark juices working
 Him to a saint's kept body,

 Trove of the turfcutters'
 Honeycombed workings.
 Now his stained face
20 Reposes at Aarhus.

II

I could risk blasphemy,
Consecrate the cauldron bog
Our holy ground and pray
Him to make germinate

25 The scattered, ambushed

Flesh of labourers,
Stockinged corpses
Laid out in the farmyards,

Tell-tale skin and teeth

30 Flecking the sleepers
Of four young brothers, trailed
For miles along the lines.

III

Something of his sad freedom
As he rode the tumbril

35 Should come to me, driving,
Saying the names

Tollund, Grabaulle, Nebelgard,
Watching the pointing hands
Of country people,

40 Not knowing their tongue.

Out there in Jutland
In the old man-killing parishes
I will feel lost,
Unhappy and at home.

Westering

In California

1 I sit under Rand McNally's
'Official Map of the Moon' –
The colour of frogskin,
Its enlarged pores held

5 Open and one called
'Pitiscus' at eye level –
Recalling the last night
In Donegal, my shadow

Neat upon the whitewash
10 From her bony shine,
The cobbles of the yard
Lit pale as eggs.

Summer had been a free fall
Ending there,
15 The empty amphitheatre
Of the west. Good Friday

We had started out
Past shopblinds drawn on the afternoon,
Cars stilled outside still churches,
20 Bikes tilting to a wall;

We drove by,
A dwindling interruption,
As clappers smacked
On a bare altar

25 And congregations bent
 To the studded crucifix.
 What nails dropped out that hour?
 Roads unreeled, unreeled

 Falling light as casts
30 Laid down
 On shining waters.
 Under the moon's stigmata

 Six thousand miles away,
 I imagine untroubled dust,
35 A loosening gravity,
 Christ weighing by his hands.

North

- 1 I returned to a long strand,
the hammered curve of a bay,
and found only the secular
powers of the Atlantic thundering.
- 5 I faced the unmagical
invitations of Iceland,
the pathetic colonies
of Greenland, and suddenly
- those fabulous raiders,
10 those lying in Orkney and Dublin
measured against
their long swords rusting,
- those in the solid
belly of stone ships,
15 those hacked and glinting
in the gravel of thawed streams
- were ocean-deafened voices
warning me, lifted again
in violence and epiphany.
- 20 The longship's swimming tongue
- was buoyant with hindsight –
it said Thor's hammer swung
to geography and trade,
thick-witted couplings and revenges,

25 the hatreds and behind backs
 of the althing, lies and women,
 exhaustions nominated peace,
 memory incubating the spilled blood.

 It said, 'Lie down
30 in the word-hoard, burrow
 the coil and gleam
 of your furrowed brain.

 Compose in darkness.
 Expect aurora borealis
35 in the long foray
 but no cascade of light.

 Keep your eye clear
 as the bleb of the icicle,
 trust the feel of what nubbed treasure
40 your hands have known.'

Bog Queen

1 I lay waiting
between turf-face and demesne wall,
between heathery levels
and glass-toothed stone.

5 My body was braille
for the creeping influences:
dawn suns groped over my head
and cooled at my feet,

through my fabrics and skins

10 the seeps of winter
digested me,
the illiterate roots

pondered and died
in the cavings

15 of stomach and socket.
I lay waiting

on the gravel bottom,
my brain darkening,
a jar of spawn

20 fermenting underground

dreams of Baltic amber.
Bruised berries under my nails,
the vital hoard reducing
in the crook of the pelvis

25 My diadem grew carious,
gemstones dropped
in the peat floe
like the bearings of history.

My sash was a black glacier
30 wrinkling, dyed weaves
and phoenician stitchwork
retted on my breasts'

soft moraines.
I knew winter cold
35 like the nuzzle of fjords
at my thighs -

the soaked fledge, the heavy
swaddle of hides.
My skull hibernated
40 in the wet nest of my hair.

Which they robbed.
I was barbered
and stripped
by a turfcutter's spade

45 who veiled me again
and packed coomb softly
between the stone jambs
at my head and my feet.

Till a peer's wife bribed him.
50 The plait of my hair,

a slimy birth-cord
of bog, had been cut

and I rose from the dark,
hacked bone, skull-ware,
55 frayed stitches, tufts,
small gleams on the bank.

The Grauballe Man

1 As if he had been poured
 in tar, he lies
 on a pillow of turf
 and seems to weep

5 the black river of himself.
 The grain of his wrists
 is like bog oak,
 the ball of his heel

 like a basalt egg.

10 His instep has shrunk
 cold as a swan's foot
 or a wet swamp root.

 His hips are the ridge
 and purse of a mussel,

15 his spine an eel arrested
 under a glisten of mud.

 The head lifts,
 the chin is a visor
 raised above the vent

20 of his slashed throat

 that has tanned and toughened.

 The cured wound
 opens inwards to a dark
 elderberry place.

- 25 Who will say 'corpse'
to his vivid cast?
Who will say 'body'
to his opaque repose?
- And his rusted hair,
30 a mat unlikely
as a foetus's.
I first saw his twisted face
- in a photograph,
a head and shoulder
35 out of the peat,
bruised like a forceps baby,
- but now he lies
perfected in my memory,
down to the red horn
40 of his nails,
- hung in the scales
with beauty and atrocity:
with the Dying Gaul
too strictly compassed
- 45 on his shield,
with the actual weight
of each hooded victim,
slashed and dumped.

Punishment

1 I can feel the tug
of the halter at the nape
of her neck, the wind
on her naked front.

5 It blows her nipples
to amber beads,
it shakes the frail rigging
of her ribs.

I can see her drowned
10 body in the bog,
the weighing stone,
the floating rods and boughs.

Under which at first
she was a barked sapling
15 that is dug up
oak-bone, brain-firkin:

her shaved head
like a stubble of black corn,
her blindfold a soiled bandage,
20 her noose a ring

to store
the memories of love.
Little adulteress,
before they punished you

25 you were flaxen-haired,
 undernourished, and your
 tar-black face was beautiful.
 My poor scapegoat,

 I almost love you
30 but would have cast, I know,
 the stones of silence.
 I am the artful voyeur

 of your brain's exposed
 and darkened combs,
35 your muscles' webbing
 and all your numbered bones:

 I who have stood dumb
 when your betraying sisters,
 cauled in tar,
40 wept by the railings,

 who would connive
 in civilized outrage
 yet understand the exact
 and tribal, intimate revenge.

Act of Union

I

- 1 Tonight, a first movement, a pulse,
 As if the rain in bogland gathered head
 To slip and flood: a bog-burst,
 A gash breaking open the ferny bed.
- 5 Your back is a firm line of eastern coast
 And arms and legs are thrown
 Beyond your gradual hills. I caress
 The heaving province where our past has grown.
 I am the tall kingdom over your shoulder
- 10 That you would neither cajole nor ignore.
 Conquest is a lie. I grow older
 Conceding your half-independent shore
 Within whose borders now my legacy
 Culminates inexorably.

II

- 15 And I am still imperially
 Male, leaving you with the pain,
 The rending process in the colony,
 The battering ram, the boom burst from within.
 The act sprouted an obstinate fifth column
- 20 Whose stance is growing unilateral.
 His heart beneath your heart is a wardrum
 Mustering force. His parasitical
 And ignorant little fists already
 Beat at your borders and I know they're cocked
- 25 At me across the water. No treaty
 I foresee will salve completely your tracked
 And stretchmarked body, the big pain
 That leaves you raw, like opened ground, again.

The Toome Road

- 1 One morning early I met armoured cars
 In convoy, warbling along on powerful tyres,
 All camouflaged with broken alder branches,
 And headphoned soldiers standing up in turrets.
- 5 How long were they approaching down my roads
 As if they owned them? The whole country was
 sleeping.
- I had rights-of-way, fields, cattle in my keeping,
 Tractors hitched to buckrakes in open sheds,
- 10 Silos, chill gates, wet slates, the greens and reds
 Of outhouse roofs. Whom should I run to tell
 Among all of those with their back doors on the latch
 For the bringer of bad news, that small-hours visitant
 Who, by being expected, might be kept distant?
- 15 Sowers of seed, erectors of headstones ...
 O charioteers, above your dormant guns,
 It stands here still, stands vibrant as you pass,
 The invisible, untapped omphalos.

4 William Wordsworth selection

Lines composed a few miles above Tintern Abbey

On revisiting the banks of the Wye during a tour.
July 13, 1798.

- 1 Five years have past; five summers, with the length
Of five long winters! and again I hear
These waters, rolling from their mountain-springs
With a soft inland murmur. – Once again
- 5 Do I behold these steep and lofty cliffs,
That on a wild secluded scene impress
Thoughts of more deep seclusion; and connect
The landscape with the quiet of the sky.
The day is come when I again repose
- 10 Here, under this dark sycamore, and view
These plots of cottage-ground, these orchard-tufts,
Which at this season, with their unripe fruits,
Are clad in one green hue, and lose themselves
'Mid groves and copses. Once again I see
- 15 These hedge-rows, hardly hedge-rows, little lines
Of sportive wood run wild: these pastoral farms,
Green to the very door; and wreaths of smoke
Sent up, in silence, from among the trees!
With some uncertain notice, as might seem
- 20 Of vagrant dwellers in the houseless woods,
Or of some Hermit's cave, where by his fire
The Hermit sits alone.

These beauteous forms,
Through a long absence, have not been to me
25 As is a landscape to a blind man's eye:
But oft, in lonely rooms, and 'mid the din
Of towns and cities, I have owed to them,
In hours of weariness, sensations sweet,
Felt in the blood, and felt along the heart;
30 And passing even into my purer mind,
With tranquil restoration: – feelings too
Of unremembered pleasure: such, perhaps,
As have no slight or trivial influence
On that best portion of a good man's life,
35 His little, nameless, unremembered, acts
Of kindness and of love. Nor less, I trust,
To them I may have owed another gift,
Of aspect more sublime; that blessed mood,
In which the burthen of the mystery,
40 In which the heavy and the weary weight
Of all this unintelligible world,
Is lightened: – that serene and blessed mood,
In which the affections gently lead us on, –
Until, the breath of this corporeal frame
45 And even the motion of our human blood
Almost suspended, we are laid asleep
In body, and become a living soul:
While with an eye made quiet by the power
Of harmony, and the deep power of joy,
50 We see into the life of things.

If this
Be but a vain belief, yet, oh! how oft –
In darkness and amid the many shapes

- Of joyless daylight; when the fretful stir
55 Unprofitable, and the fever of the world,
Have hung upon the beatings of my heart –
How oft, in spirit, have I turned to thee,
O sylvan Wye! thou wanderer thro' the woods,
How often has my spirit turned to thee!
- 60 And now, with gleams of half-extinguished thought,
With many recognitions dim and faint,
And somewhat of a sad perplexity,
The picture of the mind revives again:
While here I stand, not only with the sense
65 Of present pleasure, but with pleasing thoughts
That in this moment there is life and food
For future years. And so I dare to hope,
Though changed, no doubt, from what I was when first
I came among these hills; when like a roe
70 I bounded o'er the mountains, by the sides
Of the deep rivers, and the lonely streams,
Wherever nature led: more like a man
Flying from something that he dreads, than one
Who sought the thing he loved. For nature then
75 (The coarser pleasures of my boyish days,
And their glad animal movements all gone by)
To me was all in all. – I cannot paint
What then I was. The sounding cataract
Haunted me like a passion: the tall rock,
80 The mountain, and the deep and gloomy wood,
Their colours and their forms, were then to me
An appetite; a feeling and a love,
That had no need of a remoter charm,
By thought supplied, not any interest

- 85 Unborrowed from the eye. – That time is past,
And all its aching joys are now no more,
And all its dizzy raptures. Not for this
Faint I, nor mourn nor murmur; other gifts
Have followed; for such loss, I would believe,
90 Abundant recompense. For I have learned
To look on nature, not as in the hour
Of thoughtless youth; but hearing often-times
The still sad music of humanity,
Nor harsh nor grating, though of ample power
95 To chasten and subdue. And I have felt
A presence that disturbs me with the joy
Of elevated thoughts; a sense sublime
Of something far more deeply interfused,
Whose dwelling is the light of setting suns,
100 And the round ocean and the living air,
And the blue sky, and in the mind of man:
A motion and a spirit, that impels
All thinking things, all objects of all thought,
And rolls through all things. Therefore am I still
105 A lover of the meadows and the woods,
And mountains; and of all that we behold
From this green earth; of all the mighty world
Of eye, and ear, – both what they half create,
And what perceive; well pleased to recognise
110 In nature and the language of the sense
The anchor of my purest thoughts, the nurse,
The guide, the guardian of my heart, and soul
Of all my moral being.

Nor perchance,
115 If I were not thus taught, should I the more

Suffer my genial spirits to decay:
For thou art with me here upon the banks
Of this fair river; thou my dearest Friend,
My dear, dear Friend; and in thy voice I catch
120 The language of my former heart, and read
My former pleasures in the shooting lights
Of thy wild eyes. Oh! yet a little while
May I behold in thee what I was once,
My dear, dear Sister! and this prayer I make,
125 Knowing that Nature never did betray
The heart that loved her; 'tis her privilege,
Through all the years of this our life, to lead
From joy to joy: for she can so inform
The mind that is within us, so impress
130 With quietness and beauty, and so feed
With lofty thoughts, that neither evil tongues,
Rash judgments, nor the sneers of selfish men,
Nor greetings where no kindness is, nor all
The dreary intercourse of daily life,
135 Shall e'er prevail against us, or disturb
Our cheerful faith, that all which we behold
Is full of blessings. Therefore let the moon
Shine on thee in thy solitary walk;
And let the misty mountain-winds be free
140 To blow against thee: and, in after years,
When these wild ecstasies shall be matured
Into a sober pleasure; when thy mind
Shall be a mansion for all lovely forms,
Thy memory be as a dwelling-place
145 For all sweet sounds and harmonies; oh! then,
If solitude, or fear, or pain, or grief,
Should be thy portion, with what healing thoughts

Of tender joy wilt thou remember me,
And these my exhortations! Nor, perchance –
150 If I should be where I no more can hear
Thy voice, nor catch from thy wild eyes these gleams
Of past existence – wilt thou then forget
That on the banks of this delightful stream
We stood together; and that I, so long
155 A worshipper of Nature, hither came
Unwearied in that service: rather say
With warmer love – oh! with far deeper zeal
Of holier love. Nor wilt thou then forget,
That after many wanderings, many years
160 Of absence, these steep woods and lofty cliffs,
And this green pastoral landscape, were to me
More dear, both for themselves and for thy sake!

Nutting

- 1 It seems a day
 (I speak of one from many singled out)
 One of those heavenly days that cannot die;
 When, in the eagerness of boyish hope,
- 5 I left our cottage-threshold, sallying forth
 With a huge wallet o'er my shoulders slung,
 A nutting-crook in hand; and turned my steps
 Tow'rd some far-distant wood, a Figure quaint,
 Tricked out in proud disguise of cast-off weeds
- 10 Which for that service had been husbanded,
 By exhortation of my frugal Dame – –
 Motley accoutrement, of power to smile
 At thorns, and brakes, and brambles and, in truth,
 More ragged than need was! O'er pathless rocks,
- 15 Through beds of matted fern, and tangled thickets,
 Forcing my way, I came to one dear nook
 Unvisited, where not a broken bough
 Drooped with its withered leaves, ungracious sign
 Of devastation; but the hazels rose
- 20 Tall and erect, with tempting clusters hung,
 A virgin scene! – A little while I stood,
 Breathing with such suppression of the heart
 As joy delights in; and with wise restraint
 Voluptuous, fearless of a rival, eyed
- 25 The banquet; – or beneath the trees I sat
 Among the flowers, and with the flowers I played;
 A temper known to those who, after long
 And weary expectation, have been blest
 With sudden happiness beyond all hope.
- 30 Perhaps it was a bower beneath whose leaves

The violets of five seasons re-appear
And fade, unseen by any human eye;
Where fairy water-breaks do murmur on
For ever; and I saw the sparkling foam,
35 And – with my cheek on one of those green stones
That, fleeced with moss, under the shady trees,
Lay round me, scattered like a flock of sheep –
I heard the murmur and the murmuring sound,
In that sweet mood when pleasure loves to pay
40 Tribute to ease; and, of its joy secure,
The heart luxuriates with indifferent things,
Wasting its kindness on stocks and stones,
And on the vacant air. Then up I rose,
And dragged to earth both branch and bough, with crash
45 And merciless ravage: and the shady nook
Of hazels, and the green and mossy bower,
Deformed and sullied, patiently gave up
Their quiet being: and, unless I now
Confound my present feelings with the past,
50 Ere from the mutilated bower I turned
Exulting, rich beyond the wealth of kings,
I felt a sense of pain when I beheld
The silent trees, and saw the intruding sky. --
Then, dearest Maiden, move along these shades
55 In gentleness of heart; with gentle hand
Touch – for there is a spirit in the woods.

A Narrow Girdle of Rough Stones and Craggs

- 1 A narrow girdle of rough stones and crags,
A rude and natural causeway, interposed
Between the water and a winding slope
Of copse and thicket, leaves the eastern shore
- 5 Of Grasmere safe in its own privacy:
And there myself and two beloved Friends,
One calm September morning, ere the mist
Had altogether yielded to the sun,
Sauntered on this retired and difficult way.
- 10 – Ill suits the road with one in haste; but we
Played with our time; and, as we strolled along,
It was our occupation to observe
Such objects as the waves had tossed ashore –
Feather, or leaf, or weed, or withered bough,
- 15 Each on the other heaped, along the line
Of the dry wreck. And, in our vacant mood,
Not seldom did we stop to watch some tuft
Of dandelion seed or thistle's beard,
That skimmed the surface of the dead calm lake,
- 20 Suddenly halting now – a lifeless stand!
And starting off again with freak as sudden;
In all its sportive wanderings, all the while,
Making report of an invisible breeze
That was its wings, its chariot, and its horse,
- 25 Its playmate, rather say, its moving soul.
– And often, trifling with a privilege
Alike indulged to all, we paused, one now,
And now the other, to point out, perchance
To pluck, some flower or water-weed, too fair
- 30 Either to be divided from the place

- On which it grew, or to be left alone
To its own beauty. Many such there are,
Fair ferns and flowers, and chiefly that tall fern,
So stately, of the Queen Osmunda named;
35 Plant lovelier, in its own retired abode
On Grasmere's beach, than Naiad by the side
Of Grecian brook, or Lady of the Mere,
Sole-sitting by the shores of old romance.
– So fared we that bright morning: from the fields
40 Meanwhile, a noise was heard, the busy mirth
Of reapers, men and women, boys and girls.
Delighted much to listen to those sounds,
And feeding thus our fancies, we advanced
Along the indented shore; when suddenly,
45 Through a thin veil of glittering haze was seen
Before us, on a point of jutting land,
The tall and upright figure of a Man
Attired in peasant's garb, who stood alone,
Angling beside the margin of the lake.
50 'Improvident and reckless,' we exclaimed,
'The Man must be, who thus can lose a day
Of the mid harvest, when the labourer's hire
Is ample, and some little might be stored
Wherewith to cheer him in the winter time.'
55 Thus talking of that Peasant, we approached
Close to the spot where with his rod and line
He stood alone; whereat he turned his head
To greet us – and we saw a Man worn down
By sickness, gaunt and lean, with sunken cheeks
60 And wasted limbs, his legs so long and lean
That for my single self I looked at them,
Forgetful of the body they sustained. –

Too weak to labour in the harvest field,
The Man was using his best skill to gain
65 A pittance from the dead unfeeling lake
That knew not of his wants. I will not say
What thoughts immediately were ours, nor how
The happy idleness of that sweet morn,
With all its lovely images, was changed
70 To serious musing and to self-reproach.
Nor did we fail to see within ourselves
What need there is to be reserved in speech,
And temper all our thoughts with charity.
– Therefore, unwilling to forget that day,
75 My Friend, Myself, and She who then received
The same admonishment, have called the place
By a memorial name, uncouth indeed
As e'er by mariner was given to bay
Or foreland, on a new-discovered coast;
80 And Point Rash-Judgement is the Name it bears.

Michael

- 1 If from the public way you turn your steps
Up the tumultuous brook of Greenhead Ghyll
You will suppose that with an upright path
Your feet must struggle; in such bold ascent
- 5 The pastoral mountains front you, face to face.
But, courage! for around that boisterous brook
The mountains have all opened out themselves,
And made a hidden valley of their own.
No habitation can be seen; but they
- 10 Who journey thither find themselves alone
With a few sheep, with rocks and stones, and kites
That overhead are sailing in the sky.
It is in truth an utter solitude;
Nor should I have made mention of this Dell
- 15 But for one object which you might pass by,
Might see and notice not. Beside the brook
Appears a straggling heap of unhewn stones!
And to that simple object appertains
A story – unenriched with strange events,
- 20 Yet not unfit, I deem, for the fireside,
Or for the summer shade. It was the first
Of those domestic tales that spake to me
Of Shepherds, dwellers in the valleys, men
Whom I already loved; – not verily
- 25 For their own sakes, but for the fields and hills
Where was their occupation and abode.
And hence this Tale, while I was yet a Boy
Careless of books, yet having felt the power
Of Nature, by the gentle agency
- 30 Of natural objects, led me on to feel

- For passions that were not my own, and think
(At random and imperfectly indeed)
On man, the heart of man, and human life.
Therefore, although it be a history
- 35 Homely and rude, I will relate the same
For the delight of a few natural hearts;
And, with yet fonder feeling, for the sake
Of youthful Poets, who among these hills
Will be my second self when I am gone.
- 40 Upon the forest-side in Grasmere Vale
There dwelt a Shepherd, Michael was his name;
An old man, stout of heart, and strong of limb.
His bodily frame had been from youth to age
Of an unusual strength: his mind was keen,
- 45 Intense, and frugal, apt for all affairs,
And in his shepherd's calling he was prompt
And watchful more than ordinary men.
Hence had he learned the meaning of all winds,
Of blasts of every tone; and oftentimes,
- 50 When others heeded not, he heard the South
Make subterraneous music, like the noise
Of bagpipers on distant Highland hills.
The Shepherd, at such warning, of his flock
Bethought him, and he to himself would say,
- 55 "The winds are now devising work for me!"
And, truly, at all times, the storm, that drives
The traveller to a shelter, summoned him
Up to the mountains: he had been alone
Amid the heart of many thousand mists,
- 60 That came to him, and left him, on the heights.
So lived he till his eightieth year was past.

And grossly that man errs, who should suppose
That the green valleys, and the streams and rocks,
Were things indifferent to the Shepherds's thoughts.
65 Fields, where with cheerful spirits he had breathed
The common air; hills, which with vigorous step
He had so often climbed; which had impressed
So many incidents upon his mind
Of hardship, skill or courage, joy or fear;
70 Which, like a book, preserved the memory
Of the dumb animals, whom he had saved,
Had fed or sheltered, linking to such acts
The certainty of honourable gain;
Those fields, those hills – what could they less? had laid
75 Strong hold on his affections, were to him
A pleasurable feeling of blind love,
The pleasure which there is in life itself.

His days had not been passed in singleness.
His Helpmate was a comely matron, old –
80 Though younger than himself full twenty years.
She was a woman of a stirring life,
Whose heart was in her house: two wheels she had
Of antique form; this large, for spinning wool;
That small, for flax; and, if one wheel had rest,
85 It was because the other was at work.
The Pair had but one inmate in their house,
An only Child, who had been born to them
When Michael, telling o'er his years, began
To deem that he was old, – in shepherd's phrase,
90 With one foot in the grave. This only Son,
With two brave sheep-dogs tried in many a storm,
The one of an inestimable worth,

Made all their household. I may truly say,
That they were as a proverb in the vale
95 For endless industry. When day was gone,
And from their occupations out of doors
The Son and Father were come home, even then,
Their labour did not cease; unless when all
Turned to the cleanly supper-board, and there,
100 Each with a mess of pottage and skimmed milk,
Sat round the basket piled with oaten cakes,
And their plain home-made cheese. Yet when the meal
Was ended, Luke (for so the Son was named)
And his old Father both betook themselves
105 To such convenient work as might employ
Their hands by the fireside; perhaps to card
Wool for the Housewife's spindle, or repair
Some injury done to sickle, flail, or scythe,
Or other implement of house or field.

110 Down from the ceiling, by the chimney's edge,
That in our ancient uncouth country style
With huge and black projection overbrowed
Large space beneath, as duly as the light
Of day grew dim the Housewife hung a lamp;
115 An aged utensil, which had performed
Service beyond all others of its kind.
Early at evening did it burn – and late,
Surviving comrade of uncounted hours,
Which, going by from year to year, had found,
120 And left, the couple neither gay perhaps
Nor cheerful, yet with objects and with hopes,
Living a life of eager industry.
And now, when Luke had reached his eighteenth year,

- There by the light of this old lamp they sat,
125 Father and Son, while far into the night
The Housewife plied her own peculiar work,
Making the cottage through the silent hours
Murmur as with the sound of summer flies.
This light was famous in its neighbourhood,
130 And was a public symbol of the life
That thrifty Pair had lived. For, as it chanced,
Their cottage on a plot of rising ground
Stood single, with large prospect, north and south,
High into Easedale, up to Dunmail-Raise,
135 And westward to the village near the lake;
And from this constant light, so regular
And so far seen, the House itself, by all
Who dwelt within the limits of the vale,
Both old and young, was named The Evening Star.
- 140 Thus living on through such a length of years,
The Shepherd, if he loved himself, must needs
Have loved his Helpmate; but to Michael's heart
This son of his old age was yet more dear –
Less from instinctive tenderness, the same
145 Fond spirit that blindly works in the blood of all –
Than that a child, more than all other gifts
That earth can offer to declining man,
Brings hope with it, and forward-looking thoughts,
And stirrings of inquietude, when they
150 By tendency of nature needs must fail.
Exceeding was the love he bare to him,
His heart and his heart's joy! For often-times
Old Michael, while he was a babe in arms,
Had done him female service, not alone

- 155 For pastime and delight, as is the use
Of fathers, but with patient mind enforced
To acts of tenderness; and he had rocked
His cradle, as with a woman's gentle hand.
- And in a later time, ere yet the Boy
- 160 Had put on boy's attire, did Michael love,
Albeit of a stern unbending mind,
To have the Young-one in his sight, when he
Wrought in the field, or on his shepherd's stool
Sat with a fettered sheep before him stretched
- 165 Under the large old oak, that near his door
Stood single, and, from matchless depth of shade,
Chosen for the Shearer's covert from the sun,
Thence in our rustic dialect was called
The Clipping Tree, a name which yet it bears.
- 170 There, while they two were sitting in the shade,
With others round them, earnest all and blithe,
Would Michael exercise his heart with looks
Of fond correction and reproof bestowed
Upon the Child, if he disturbed the sheep
- 175 By catching at their legs, or with his shouts
Scared them, while they lay still beneath the shears.
- And when by Heaven's good grace the boy grew up
A healthy Lad, and carried in his cheek
Two steady roses that were five years old;
- 180 Then Michael from a winter coppice cut
With his own hand a sapling, which he hooped
With iron, making it throughout in all
Due requisites a perfect shepherd's staff,
And gave it to the Boy; wherewith equipt

185 He as a watchman oftentimes was placed
At gate or gap, to stem or turn the flock;
And, to his office prematurely called,
There stood the urchin, as you will divine,
Something between a hindrance and a help,
190 And for this cause not always, I believe,
Receiving from his Father hire of praise;
Though nought was left undone which staff, or voice,
Or looks, or threatening gestures, could perform.

But soon as Luke, full ten years old, could stand
195 Against the mountain blasts; and to the heights,
Not fearing toil, nor length of weary ways,
He with his Father daily went, and they
Were as companions, why should I relate
That objects which the Shepherd loved before
200 Were dearer now? that from the Boy there came
Feelings and emanations – things which were
Light to the sun and music to the wind;
And that the old Man's heart seemed born again?

Thus in his Father's sight the Boy grew up:
205 And now, when he had reached his eighteenth year,
He was his comfort and his daily hope.
While in this sort the simple household lived
From day to day, to Michael's ear there came
Distressful tidings. Long before the time
210 Of which I speak, the Shepherd had been bound
In surety for his brother's son, a man
Of an industrious life, and ample means;
But unforeseen misfortunes suddenly
Had prest upon him; and old Michael now

- 215 Was summoned to discharge the forfeiture,
A grievous penalty, but little less
Than half his substance. This unlooked-for claim,
At the first hearing, for a moment took
More hope out of his life than he supposed
- 220 That any old man ever could have lost.
As soon as he had armed himself with strength
To look his trouble in the face, it seemed
The Shepherd's sole resource to sell at once
A portion of his patrimonial fields.
- 225 Such was his first resolve; he thought again,
And his heart failed him. "Isabel," said he,
Two evenings after he had heard the news,
"I have been toiling more than seventy years,
And in the open sunshine of God's love
- 230 Have we all lived; yet, if these fields of ours
Should pass into a stranger's hand, I think
That I could not lie quiet in my grave.
Our lot is a hard lot; the sun himself
Has scarcely been more diligent than I;
- 235 And I have lived to be a fool at last
To my own family. An evil man
That was, and made an evil choice, if he
Were false to us; and, if he were not false,
There are ten thousand to whom loss like this
- 240 Had been no sorrow. I forgive him; – but
'Twere better to be dumb than to talk thus.
- When I began, my purpose was to speak
Of remedies and of a cheerful hope.
Our Luke shall leave us, Isabel; the land
- 245 Shall not go from us, and it shall be free;

He shall possess it, free as is the wind
That passes over it. We have, thou know'st,
Another kinsman – he will be our friend
In this distress. He is a prosperous man,
250 Thriving in trade – and Luke to him shall go,
And with his kinsman's help and his own thrift
He quickly will repair this loss, and then
He may return to us. If here he stay,
What can be done? Where every one is poor,
255 What can be gained?"

At this the old Man paused,
And Isabel sat silent, for her mind
Was busy, looking back into past times.
There's Richard Bateman, thought she to herself,
260 He was a parish-boy – at the church-door
They made a gathering for him, shillings, pence,
And halfpennies, wherewith the neighbours bought
A basket, which they filled with pedlar's wares;
And, with this basket on his arm, the lad
265 Went up to London, found a master there,
Who, out of many, chose the trusty boy
To go and overlook his merchandise
Beyond the seas; where he grew wondrous rich,
And left estates and monies to the poor,
270 And, at his birth-place, built a chapel floored
With marble, which he sent from foreign lands.
These thoughts, and many others of like sort,
Passed quickly through the mind of Isabel,
And her face brightened. The old Man was glad,
275 And thus resumed: – "Well, Isabel! this scheme
These two days has been meat and drink to me.
Far more than we have lost is left us yet.

We have enough – I wish indeed that I
Were younger; – but this hope is a good hope.

280 Make ready Luke's best garments, of the best
Buy for him more, and let us send him forth
Tomorrow, or the next day, or tonight:
If he *could* go, the boy should go tonight."

Here Michael ceased, and to the fields went forth

285 With a light heart. The Housewife for five days
Was restless morn and night, and all day long
Wrought on with her best fingers to prepare
Things needful for the journey of her son.
But Isabel was glad when Sunday came

290 To stop her in her work: for, when she lay
By Michael's side, she through the last two nights
Heard him, how he was troubled in his sleep:
And when they rose at morning she could see
That all his hopes were gone. That day at noon

295 She said to Luke, while they two by themselves
Were sitting at the door, "Thou must not go:
We have no other Child but thee to lose,
None to remember – do not go away,
For if thou leave thy Father he will die."

300 The Youth made answer with a jocund voice;
And Isabel, when she had told her fears,
Recovered heart. That evening her best fare
Did she bring forth, and all together sat
Like happy people round a Christmas fire.

305 With daylight Isabel resumed her work;
And all the ensuing week the house appeared
As cheerful as a grove in Spring: at length

The expected letter from their kinsman came,
With kind assurances that he would do
310 His utmost for the welfare of the Boy;
To which requests were added, that forthwith
He might be sent to him. Ten times or more
The letter was read over; Isabel
Went forth to show it to the neighbours round;
315 Nor was there at that time on English land
A prouder heart than Luke's. When Isabel
Had to her house returned, the old man said,
"He shall depart tomorrow." To this word
The Housewife answered, talking much of things
320 Which, if at such short notice he should go,
Would surely be forgotten. But at length
She gave consent, and Michael was at ease.

Near the tumultuous brook of Green-head Ghyll,
In that deep valley, Michael had designed
325 To build a Sheep-fold; and, before he heard
The tidings of his melancholy loss,
For this same purpose he had gathered up
A heap of stones, which by the streamlet's edge
Lay thrown together, ready for the work.
330 With Luke that evening thitherward he walked:
And soon as they had reached the place he stopped,
And thus the old Man spake to him: – "My son,
Tomorrow thou wilt leave me: with full heart
I look upon thee, for thou art the same
335 That wert a promise to me ere thy birth,
And all thy life hast been my daily joy.
I will relate to thee some little part
Of our two histories; 'twill do thee good

When thou art from me, even if I should touch
340 On things thou canst not know of. – After thou
First cam'st into the world – as oft befalls
To new-born infants – thou didst sleep away
Two days, and blessings from thy Father's tongue
Then fell upon thee. Day by day passed on,
345 And still I loved thee with increasing love.
Never to living ear came sweeter sounds
Than when I heard thee by our own fireside
First uttering, without words, a natural tune;
While thou, a feeding babe, didst in thy joy
350 Sing at thy Mother's breast. Month followed month,
And in the open fields my life was passed
And on the mountains; else I think that thou
Hadst been brought up upon thy Father's knees.
But we were playmates, Luke: among these hills,
355 As well thou knowest, in us the old and young
Have played together, nor with me didst thou
Lack any pleasure which a boy can know."
Luke had a manly heart; but at these words
He sobbed aloud. The old Man grasped his hand,
360 And said, "Nay, do not take it so – I see
That these are things of which I need not speak.
– Even to the utmost I have been to thee
A kind and a good Father: and herein
I but repay a gift which I myself
365 Received at others' hands; for, though now old
Beyond the common life of man, I still
Remember them who loved me in my youth.
Both of them sleep together: here they lived,
As all their Forefathers had done; and, when
370 At length their time was come, they were not loth

- 370 To give their bodies to the family mould.
I wished that thou should'st live the life they lived,
But, 'tis a long time to look back, my Son,
And see so little gain from threescore years.
- 375 These fields were burthened when they came to me;
Till I was forty years of age, not more
Than half of my inheritance was mine.
I toiled and toiled; God blessed me in my work,
And till these three weeks past the land was free.
- 380 – It looks as if it never could endure
Another Master. Heaven forgive me, Luke,
If I judge ill for thee, but it seems good
That thou should'st go.”
At this the old Man paused;
- 385 Then, pointing to the stones near which they stood,
Thus, after a short silence, he resumed:
“This was a work for us; and now, my Son,
It is a work for me. But, lay one stone –
Here, lay it for me, Luke, with thine own hands.
- 390 Nay, Boy, be of good hope; – we both may live
To see a better day. At eighty-four
I still am strong and hale; – do thou thy part;
I will do mine. – I will begin again
With many tasks that were resigned to thee:
- 395 Up to the heights, and in among the storms,
Will I without thee go again, and do
All works which I was wont to do alone,
Before I knew thy face. – Heaven bless thee, Boy!
Thy heart these two weeks has been beating fast
- 400 With many hopes; it should be so – yes – yes –
I knew that thou could'st never have a wish
To leave me, Luke: thou hast been bound to me

- Only by links of love: when thou art gone,
What will be left to us! – But, I forget
405 My purposes. Lay now the corner-stone,
As I requested; and hereafter, Luke,
When thou art gone away, should evil men
Be thy companions, think of me, my Son,
And of this moment; hither turn thy thoughts,
410 And God will strengthen thee: amid all fear
And all temptation, Luke, I pray that thou
May'st bear in mind the life thy Fathers lived,
Who, being innocent, did for that cause
Bestir them in good deeds. Now, fare thee well –
415 When thou return'st, thou in this place wilt see
A work which is not here: a covenant
'Twill be between us; but, whatever fate
Befall thee, I shall love thee to the last,
And bear thy memory with me to the grave.”
- 420 The Shepherd ended here; and Luke stooped down,
And, as his Father had requested, laid
The first stone of the Sheep-fold. At the sight
The old Man's grief broke from him; to his heart
He pressed his Son, he kissed him and wept;
425 And to the house together they returned.
– Hushed was that House in peace, or seeming peace,
Ere the night fell: – with morrow's dawn the Boy
Began his journey, and, when he had reached
The public way, he put on a bold face;
430 And all the neighbours, as he passed their doors,
Came forth with wishes and with farewell prayers,
That followed him till he was out of sight.
A good report did from their Kinsman come,

Of Luke and his well-doing: and the Boy

435 Wrote loving letters, full of wondrous news,
Which, as the Housewife phrased it, were throughout
“The prettiest letters that were ever seen.”

Both parents read them with rejoicing hearts.
So, many months passed on: and once again

440 The Shepherd went about his daily work
With confident and cheerful thoughts; and now
Sometimes when he could find a leisure hour
He to that valley took his way, and there
Wrought at the Sheep-fold. Meantime Luke began

445 To slacken in his duty; and, at length,
He in the dissolute city gave himself
To evil courses: ignominy and shame
Fell on him, so that he was driven at last
To seek a hiding-place beyond the seas.

450 There is a comfort in the strength of love;
‘Twill make a thing endurable, which else
Would upset the brain, or break the heart:
I have conversed with more than one who well
Remember the old Man, and what he was

455 Years after he had heard this heavy news.
His bodily frame had been from youth to age
Of an unusual strength. Among the rocks
He went, and still looked up to sun and cloud,
And listened to the wind; and, as before,

460 Performed all kinds of labour for his sheep,
And for the land, his small inheritance.
And to that hollow dell from time to time
Did he repair, to build the Fold of which
His flock had need. ‘Tis not forgotten yet

465 The pity which was then in every heart
For the old Man – and 'tis believed by all
That many and many a day he thither went,
And never lifted up a single stone.

There, by the Sheep-fold, sometimes was he seen
470 Sitting alone, or with his faithful Dog,
Then old, beside him, lying at his feet.
The length of full seven years, from time to time,
He at the building of this Sheep-fold wrought,
And left the work unfinished when he died.
475 Three years, or little more, did Isabel
Survive her Husband: at her death the estate
Was sold, and went into a stranger's hand.
The Cottage which was named The Evening Star
Is gone - the ploughshare has been through the ground
480 On which it stood; great changes have been wrought
In all the neighbourhood: – yet the oak is left
That grew beside their door; and the remains
Of the unfinished Sheep-fold may be seen
Beside the boisterous brook of Green-head Ghyll.

Composed upon Westminster Bridge

- 1 Earth has not anything to show more fair:
Dull would he be of soul who could pass by
A sight so touching in its majesty:
This City now doth, like a garment, wear
- 5 The beauty of the morning; silent, bare,
Ships, towers, domes, theatres, and temples lie
Open unto the fields, and to the sky;
All bright and glittering in the smokeless air.
Never did sun more beautifully steep
- 10 In his first splendour, valley, rock, or hill;
Ne'er saw I, never felt, a calm so deep!
The river glideth at his own sweet will:
Dear God! the very houses seem asleep;
And all that mighty heart is lying still!

Yarrow Unvisited

- 1 From Stirling castle we had seen
The mazy Forth unravelled;
Had trod the banks of Clyde, and Tay,
And with the Tweed had travelled;
- 5 And when we came to Clovenford,
Then said my “winsome Marrow”,
“Whate’er betide, we’ll turn aside,
And see the Braes of Yarrow.”
- “Let Yarrow folk, *frae* Selkirk town,
10 Who have been buying, selling,
Go back to Yarrow, ‘tis their own;
Each maiden to her dwelling!
On Yarrow’s banks let her herons feed,
Hares couch, and rabbits burrow!
- 15 But we will downward with the Tweed
Nor turn aside to Yarrow.
- “There’s Galla Water, Leader Haughs,
Both lying right before us;
And Dryborough, where with chiming Tweed
20 The lintwhites sing in chorus;
There’s pleasant Tiviot-dale, a land
Made blithe with plough and harrow:
Why throw away a needful day
To go in search of Yarrow?
- 25 “What’s Yarrow but a river bare,
That glides the dark hills under?
There are a thousand such elsewhere

As worthy of your wonder.”

– Strange words they seemed of slight and scorn;

30 My True-love sighed for sorrow;
And looked me in the face, to think
I thus could speak of Yarrow!
“Oh! green,” said I, “are Yarrow’s holms,

And sweet is Yarrow flowing!

35 Fair hangs the apple frae the rock.
But we will leave it growing.
O’er hilly path, and open Strath,
We’ll wander Scotland thorough;
But, though so near, we will not turn
40 Into the dale of Yarrow.

“Let beeves and home-bred kine partake

The sweets of Burn-mill meadow;

The swan on still St. Mary’s Lake

Float double, swan and shadow!

45 We will not see them; will not go,
Today, nor yet tomorrow;
Enough if in our hearts we know
There’s such a place as Yarrow.

“Be Yarrow stream unseen, unknown!

50 It must, or we shall rue it:
We have a vision of our own;
Ah! why should we undo it?
The treasured dreams of times long past,
We’ll keep them, winsome Marrow!
55 For when we’re there, although ‘tis fair,
‘Twill be another Yarrow!

“If Care with freezing years should come,
And wandering seem but folly, –
Should we be loth to stir from home,
60 And yet be melancholy;
Should life be dull, and spirits low,
‘Twill soothe us in our sorrow,
That earth has something yet to show,
The bonny holms of Yarrow!”

Daffodils

- 1 I wandered lonely as a cloud
That floats on high o'er vales and hills,
When all at once I saw a crowd,
A host, of golden daffodils;
5 Beside the lake, beneath the trees,
Fluttering and dancing in the breeze.

- Continuous as the stars that shine
And twinkle on the milky way,
They stretched in never-ending line
10 Along the margin of a bay:
Ten thousand saw I at a glance,
Tossing their heads in sprightly dance.

- The waves beside them danced; but they
Out-did the sparkling waves in glee:
15 A poet could not but be gay,
In such a jocund company:
I gazed – and gazed – but little thought
What wealth the show to me had brought:

- For oft, when on my couch I lie
20 In vacant or in pensive mood,
They flash upon that inward eye
Which is the bliss of solitude;
And then my heart with pleasure fills,
And dances with the daffodils.

Elegiac Stanzas

Suggested by a picture of Peele Castle in a storm Painted by Sir George Beaumont

1 I was thy neighbour once, thou rugged Pile!
Four summer weeks I dwelt in sight of thee:
I saw thee every day; and all the while
Thy Form was sleeping on a glassy sea.

5 So pure the sky, so quiet was the air!
So like, so very like, was day to day!
Whene'er I looked, thy Image still was there;
It trembled, but it never passed away.

How perfect was the calm! it seemed no sleep;
10 No mood, which season takes away, or brings:
I could have fancied that the mighty Deep
Was even the gentlest of all gentle Things.

Ah! then, if mine had been the Painter's hand,
To express what then I saw; and add the gleam,
15 The light that never was, on sea or land,
The consecration, and the Poet's dream;

I would have planted thee, thou hoary Pile
Amid a world how different from this!
Beside a sea that could not cease to smile;
20 On tranquil land, beneath a sky of bliss.

Thou shouldst have seemed a treasure-house divine
Of peaceful years; a chronicle of heaven; –

Of all the sunbeams that did ever shine
The very sweetest had to thee been given.

25 A Picture had it been of lasting ease,
Elysian quiet, without toil or strife;
No motion but the moving tide, a breeze,
Or merely silent Nature's breathing life.

Such, in the fond illusion of my heart,
30 Such Picture would I at that time have made:
And seen the soul of truth in every part,
A steadfast peace that might not be betrayed.

So once it would have been, – 'tis so no more;
I have submitted to a new control:
35 A power is gone, which nothing can restore;
A deep distress hath humanised my Soul.

Not for a moment could I now behold
A smiling sea, and be what I have been:
The feeling of my loss will ne'er be old;
40 This, which I know, I speak with mind serene.

Then, Beaumont, Friend! who would have been the Friend,
If he had lived, of Him whom I deplore,
This work of thine I blame not, but commend;
This sea in anger, and that dismal shore.

45 O 'tis a passionate Work! — yet wise and well,
Well chosen is the spirit that is here;
That Hulk which labours in the deadly swell,
This rueful sky, this pageantry of fear!

And this huge Castle, standing here sublime,
50 I love to see the look with which it braves,
Cased in the unfeeling armour of old time,
The lightning, the fierce wind, and trampling waves.

Farewell, farewell the heart that lives alone,
Housed in a dream, at distance from the Kind!
55 Such happiness, wherever it be known,
Is to be pitied; for 'tis surely blind.

But welcome fortitude, and patient cheer,
And frequent sights of what is to be borne!
Such sights, or worse, as are before me here. –
60 Not without hope we suffer and we mourn.

Acknowledgement

The Collected Poems of Robert Frost, Vintage, 2001

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